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Statement of Diversity

Diversity may be considered a complex issue and inherently is influenced by backgrounds that may include physical traits, interests, cultures, age, education, occupation, and religion. In this statement, I want to briefly present my take on this issue, what I have experienced, my contribution, and what I hope to do in the future.

In my opinion, diversity is one of the basic characteristics of human society and is an asset indispensable to the progress of humanity. And, although diversity seems complex, it is very logical and simple in its essence, since it is very natural and is not something human beings have control over for the most part. Therefore, showing respect to different physical traits, interests, cultures, ages and the beliefs and practices of different religions is very crucial to any modern society – in general - and to college societies specifically. This critical towards creating a conducive environment for teaching and learning.

In fact, I consider diversity and tolerance to be a huge part of my heritage as well as my life since my childhood. First, my grandparents and their families were chased out of their villages and homes early in the 1940s. They were displaced and lived in immigration camps for a few years until they moved to other countries in search of work and income to raise families and live stable life. Then came the second generation – my parents – who lived in different countries and continents over the years in search of better education and work opportunities. Consequently, these positive and negative real-life situations and experiences positively influenced my attitude toward diversity and tolerance. Indeed, that broadened my horizon and influenced my choices in education, work, and marriage. Then, throughout my career, I moved and lived nationally and internationally between four different continents: North America, Africa, Europe, and the Middle East. These experiences gave me a first-hand experience in relation to what it feels like to be somewhat different or from a diverse background. Further, attending schools, living, and working in two societies that were – arguably considered - at the opposite sides of the spectrum in terms of openness and tolerance; western society and gulf-middle eastern societies; forced me to experience situations that were uncomfortable at times. My background and experiences taught me to be understanding and sensitive toward different values and backgrounds.

Contributions to Diversity

At my current institution, as a faculty member, I was actively involved in some aspects of diversity and tolerance. Individuals with disabilities are frequently marginalized in some societies because of cultural views. Therefore, I modified an undergraduate class (Introduction to Rehabilitation) to focus on the concept of disability, rehabilitation, and inclusion for students enrolled in the Special Education Program at the College of Education. The core of this class focused on discussing the World Report on Disability (World Health Organization, 2011). Due to the nature of student enrollment in this institute, all my students were females from the local

community. I like to believe that I succeeded in engaging them in an open and honest dialogue about diversity, inclusion, and bias.

Furthermore, at this current institution, I advocated for the inclusion of students with special needs in various undergraduate programs and was involved in drafting the first policy in this institute. And was involved in reviewing and commenting on an admission policy that was proposed by the department of higher education in the UAE involving students with disabilities.

What I hope to do in the future

In my opinion, diversity is an attitude and a practice, not a claim. Therefore, positively influencing college undergraduate and graduate students can only occur by example. Thus, my goal is for everyone passing through my classes to accept that people vary widely in every attribute imaginable and that this is valuable. I will continue to strive to create a positive and comfortable environment for diversity. This may include highlighting everyone's contributions, encouraging shy or junior students to express their opinions, and supporting broad collaboration. These might seem like minor actions, but these everyday experiences are what make diversity a practice. And that is what matters.

I was fortunate – as a diverse individual - throughout my education and career, to have had opportunities, support, and role models that were necessary for me to succeed. Indeed, minority and diverse students are in need of such role models and a comfortably diverse environment to succeed. Therefore, I hope that I can be a role model and influence such students to become successful tolerant clinicians. Furthermore, I will always be open to contribute to any initiative that advances diversity on or off campus.